Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣`, `<minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2>     <filen>
```

2.3.2 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
     :wq – write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
    :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
      :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.3.3 Files

```
  :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
  :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

 :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
 :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
        ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
        ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
         gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

        ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
        ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
        ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
   <enter> – open selected in current view
    Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
    Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.3.4 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
       :n – create new scratch buffer
      :bc – close current buffer
     :bca – close all buffers
     :bco – close all but current buffer
      :bn – next buffer
       ␣b – open buffer picker

      ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
      gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
      gn – go to next buffer
      gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.3.5 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
helix <file1> <file2> ... <file>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

`v3wd`	– enter select mode, select 3 words, delete

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

`.`	– any character
`*`	– zero or more
`+`	– one or more
`?`	– zero or one / lazy match
`^`	– start of line / negation in class
`$`	– end of line
`( )`	– capture group
`[ ]`	– character class
`{ }`	– repetition count
`|`	– alternation
`\`	– escape character itself

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

`u / U`	– undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	– move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	– move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	– repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	– return to normal mode

`␣ws / ␣wv`	– split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	– split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	– close current split
`␣wo`	– close all but current split
`␣ww`	– next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	– move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	– swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	– transpose split

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	– enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	– align to center
`zt`	– align to top
`zb`	– align to bottom
`zm`	– align to middle horizontally
`zj`	– scroll down
`zk`	– scroll up

2.3.6 Help

`:tutor`	– open tutorial
`␣?`	– open command palette

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

`h/j/k/l`	– left / up / down / right
`gh, g|`	– beginning of line
`<nn>g|`	– column <nn>
`gl`	– end of line
`gg`	– top of file
`<nn>G, g<nn>g`	– line <nn>
`ge`	– bottom of file
`gw`	– two-char labels on words, label to go to word
`g.`	– to last modification in current file
`gj`	– down textual line
`gk`	– up textual line
`gs`	– first non-white-space char
`gt`	– top of screen
`gc`	– middle of screen
`gb`	– bottom of screen

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.4.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

```
%      – select whole file
Alt-;  – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-:  – selection to normal direction (cursor at end)
Alt-o  – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i  – shrink selection
;      – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.5.2 By TextObjects

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v     – toggle select mode
Esc   – return to normal
)     – cycle primary selection forward
(     – cycle primary selection backward
Alt-, – remove primary selection
```

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become selections
S        – split on match
Alt-s    – split on newlines
C / Alt-C – add selection below / above
```

2.7.2 Operations

```
&          – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
,          – remove all except primary selection
Alt-,      – remove primary selection
( / )      – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
K          – keep selections matching the regex
Alt-K      – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

```
i   – before selection
a   – after selection
I   – at start of line
A   – at end of line
o   – add line and insert below cursor
O   – add line and insert above cursor
Esc – end insert (return to normal)
.   – repeat last insert
```

2.8.2 Add

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below:
          w / W – word / WORD
              p – paragraph
  (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
              m –  closest surround pair
              f – function
              t – type or class
              a – argument/parameter
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git hunk
```

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
        w / W – to start of next word / WORD
        e / E – to end of current word / WORD
        b / B – to start of current word / WORD
            x – current line, extend by line
            X – extend to line
      Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
           ]p – to next paragraph
           [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
      Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
      Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
      Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
      Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
      Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
      Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
  f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
  t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
       Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

```
           ]␣ – newline below
           [␣ – newline above
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.8.3 Delete

```
            d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
        Alt-d – delete, no save
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.8.4 Change

```
            c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
        Alt-c – change, no save
            = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.8.5 Indent Lines

```
            > – Indent line(s) containing selection
            < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
            ~ – change case
            ` – set lowercase
       Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
          ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

```
      Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
      Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

```
                J – join lines in a selection
          Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
        <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
          :sort – sort ranges in selection
        :format – format file using external formatter / language server
```

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
            y – selection -> yank buf
            p – paste yank buf after the cursor
            P – paste yank buf before the cursor
           ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
           ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
      ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
           ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
       r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
            R – replace selection with yank buf
            " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.10 Search

```
     /<regex> – search forward for regex
     ?<regex> – search backward for regex
         n, N – next, previous match
            * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
       Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
         "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
        "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
        "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
        "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.12 Macros

```
        "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
        "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.13 Jumplists

```
       Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
       Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
       Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                          Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                          Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                          Ctrl-r – insert a register content
               Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
                 Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                          Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                          Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
     Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
                    Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
                   Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
    <Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>,– usual meaning but discouraged
     <PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>,
                           <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
        Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
            <enter> – open selected
              <tab> – select next completion item
          <backtab> – select previous completion item
              Alt-b – backward a word
             Ctrl-b – backward a char
              Alt-f – forward a word
             Ctrl-f – forward a char
             Ctrl-e – to prompt end
             Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
  Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
             Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
             Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
     <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
      <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
             Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to
                      Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
             Ctrl-p – select previous history
             Ctrl-n – select next history
             Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by
                      following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                  <Home> – to first entry
                   <End> – to last entry
```

```
␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
          mm – go to matching delim
     mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
     ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
        | – replace selection(s) with output
     Alt-| – ignore output
        ! – insert output before each selection(s)
     Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
        $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.16 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.17 Editor Configuration

```
         :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
        :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.18 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

```
     Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
   Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
             <enter> – open selected
       Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without
                     closing the picker
            Ctrl-s – open horizontally
            Ctrl-v – open vertically
            Ctrl-t – toggle preview
       Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u – scroll up
Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
          <enter> – close menu and accept completion
           Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```